



LEBANON

Capital city: Beirut
Area: 4,015 sq miles (10,400 sq km)
Population: 3,700,000
Official language: Arabic
Major religions: Muslim 70%, Christian 30%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Lebanese pound
Adult literacy rate: 87%
Life expectancy: 71 years
People per doctor: 476
Televisions: 352 per 1,000 people

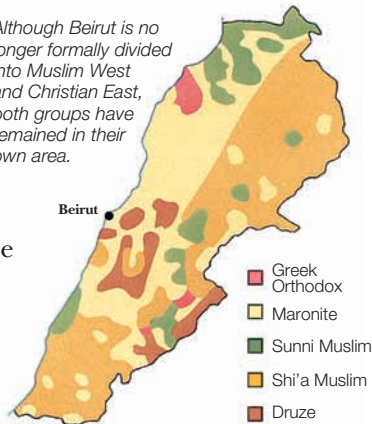
LEBANON

LEBANON IS A SMALL COUNTRY at the eastern end of the Mediterranean bordered by Syria and Israel. The people of Lebanon are mostly Arabs, belonging to a great variety of religious groups. Lebanon was once the cultural and business center of the region, but in 1975, tensions between Muslim and Christian groups led to the outbreak of a violent civil war that almost destroyed the country. Peace terms were agreed in 1989 and some stability was restored.

RELIGIOUS GROUPS

The Lebanese population is a jigsaw puzzle of religious groups, including different Christian and Muslim sects. The largest Christian group is the Maronites, who practice a form of Catholicism. Other Christian groups include the Greek Orthodox. The Muslims are mainly of the Shi'a sect, but there are also many Sunnis.

Although Beirut is no longer formally divided into Muslim West and Christian East, both groups have remained in their own area.



DRUZES

The Druze faith is an offshoot of Islam that is now considered a religion in its own right. There are about 200,000 Druzes in Lebanon, mainly living in the southern mountains. They have many customs designed to protect their community. It is impossible to become a Druze unless you are born one, and you cannot give up your faith. Marriage is only allowed within the community to ensure that the Druze faith continues.

REBUILDING BEIRUT

Before its destruction in the civil war, Beirut was a cultural center. It was known as the "Paris of the East" and was one of the region's most important ports and business centers. For many years the city lay in ruins, but a government project to rebuild Beirut has managed to restore its financial center and has succeeded in attracting visitors back to the capital.

Where people live



90% live in cities

10% live in the country



CEDAR TREES

The cedars of Lebanon are the country's symbol and appear on the national flag. In biblical times, great forests of cedar trees covered the slopes of the Lebanese mountains. Today, they survive only in a few protected groves. Some of these trees are more than 1,500 years old.



TYRE AND SIDON

The civil war ruined Lebanon's thriving tourist industry. Attempts are now being made to attract visitors back to the country's fine beaches and historical sites, such as the two cities of Tyre and Sidon. These were built by the Phoenicians some 3,000 years ago and were famous in Roman times for their glassware and purple dyes.

LEBANESE FOOD

The national dish of Lebanon is *kibbe*, made of lamb, bulgur (cracked wheat), and onions, pounded together. The mixture is shaped into balls or patties and baked or fried. Sweet pastries, stuffed with nuts and dates and covered in honey, are also popular.

Vegetables such as rutabagas and spices such as chillies are often eaten with the main meal.



Rutabaga



Chillies



Kibbe is the Lebanese national dish.

Baklava

Find out more

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